The 5-Minute Memory Workbook

Tiny Daily Habits for a Sharper, More Reliable Mind After 40



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A Six-Week Micro-Habit Programme

The 5-Minute Memory Workbook

Tiny Daily Habits for a Sharper, More Reliable Mind After 40

Five minutes a day. Six weeks. One tiny habit at a time. Built for busy adults who want an everyday memory they can count on, without memory palaces, gimmicks or guesswork.

This Workbook Belongs To

Name

My start date

Why I am doing this (one honest sentence)

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Important Information

Before You Begin

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This workbook is not medical advice. It is a practical guide to everyday habits that support attention, sleep, movement and learning. It is not designed to diagnose, treat, cure or prevent any condition, including dementia, and it does not replace advice from your doctor or another qualified health professional.

If you are worried about your memory, or if your memory has changed noticeably or suddenly, please read the page titled **When To Talk To A Doctor** and arrange an appointment. Habits help most when any medical causes have been checked first.

About the research. This workbook summarises well-known research findings in plain language. Research changes and individual results vary. The Sources page lists the studies and books behind the main ideas so that you can read further. Nothing here promises a particular result.

About supplements and products. We do not recommend any supplement, brain-training product or device. If you are considering one, speak to a pharmacist or doctor first, especially if you take regular medication.

About physical activity. Check with your doctor before starting new exercise if you have a health condition, are pregnant, are recovering from illness or injury, or have been told to limit activity. Stop and seek advice if you feel unwell.

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A Note Before We Start

Welcome

Have you ever walked into a room and forgotten why? Stood in the car park with no idea where you left the car? Lost a colleague's name halfway through introducing them? You are in good company. These slips are among the most common things people notice in their forties and fifties, and they are usually about **attention, stress, sleep and overload** rather than anything more worrying.

The good news is that everyday memory responds to everyday habits. You do not need an hour a day, a special diet or an app. You need **five minutes**, a cue you already have in your day, and a little patience. That is the whole idea of this workbook.

Over six weeks you will add one tiny habit at a time. Each one targets a different link in the memory chain: **sleep** (where memories settle), **attention** (how they get in), **movement** (how your brain feels while it works), **retrieval** (how you strengthen what you know), **encoding** (how you tag what matters) and finally a **lock-in** week that stacks it all into a single Daily Five.

You will not be asked to feel guilty, to be perfect or to start again if you miss a day. Habits are built by returning, not by streaks. Where you see a writing space, please use it. Writing things down is part of how this works, and the pages are yours to mark up, tick, cross out and scribble on.

At the start you will take a gentle self-check so that you can see where you are. At the end you will repeat it and compare. Most readers find that the comparison alone is encouraging, because it turns a vague worry into something you can actually watch change.

> **A Promise From Us**
>
> No shame, no jargon, no miracle claims. If something here does not suit you, change it. The best habit is the one you will actually do.

Let's begin.

My Notes

The Five-Minute Formula

How This Workbook Works

Every habit in this book follows the same three-part recipe. It is deliberately small so that it is easy on your worst day, not only your best one.

1. Anchor	An existing routine that already happens every day: pouring the first coffee, brushing your teeth, shutting the laptop, parking the car. The anchor is your reminder, so you never have to rely on remembering to remember.
2. Tiny Habit	A five-minute action (often less) that you do straight after the anchor. You will use the phrase: *After I [anchor], I will [tiny habit].*
3. Celebrate	A small, genuine moment of "done": a tick on the tracker, a quiet fist-pump, a word of thanks to yourself. Feeling good right after the habit is what teaches your brain to repeat it.

Your Six-Week Map

Week	Focus	Your Tiny Habit
Week 1	Sleep	The Five-Minute Wind-Down
Week 2	Attention	One Thing, Out Loud
Week 3	Movement	The Five-Minute Movement Snack
Week 4	Retrieval	Recall Before You Check
Week 5	Encoding	The Three-Second Tag
Week 6	Lock-In	The Daily Five

Inside Each Week

- An **opener** with your habit card and a preparation checklist.
- Two **learn** pages in plain language, plus common traps and fixes.
- A **planner** where you write your anchor and your if-then plans.
- Four short **practice exercises**, then a **daily log** for all seven days.
- A **weekly review** and a page for questions and notes.

Where Everything Lives

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Part One: Why We Forget

The Science, In Plain Language

Memory is not one thing. It is a chain with three main links: **encoding** (taking something in), **storage** (keeping it) and **retrieval** (getting it back when you need it). Everyday forgetting can happen at any link, but the most common culprit is the first one.

Psychologist Daniel Schacter calls this "absent-mindedness": you did not forget where you put your keys, you never properly registered putting them down because your attention was elsewhere. No amount of "memory training" helps with something that was never recorded. This is why the second week of this programme is about attention.

Several ordinary things make the chain weaker in midlife, and none of them are character flaws:

- **Overload.** Work, family, money and a phone that never stops mean your attention is divided most of the day.
- **Stress and low mood.** A worried mind has less room for new information, and stress hormones can interfere with recall.
- **Sleep.** Short or broken sleep reduces attention the next day and gives memories less time to settle overnight.
- **Hormonal and life changes.** Many people notice "brain fog" during perimenopause and menopause, and other life transitions can also play a part.
- **Health factors.** Some medications, thyroid problems, low vitamin B12, depression, anxiety and untreated sleep apnoea can all affect thinking and memory. This is why checking with a doctor matters when changes are noticeable.
- **Autopilot.** The more routine a day is, the less each moment stands out, so the more easily it blurs together.

> **Key Idea**
>
> Most midlife forgetfulness is a signal that your brain is busy, tired or distracted, not that it is failing. Small changes to attention, sleep and routine are a sensible place to start.

What habits cannot do. No habit in this book can promise to prevent or reverse any disease of the brain. What the research does support is that everyday behaviours such as sleeping well, staying active, paying focused attention and practising recall are linked with better day-to-day thinking, and are good for you for many other reasons too.

Part Two: Why Tiny Habits Work

The Science, In Plain Language

Small is a strategy, not a compromise. Big plans fail on tired days. A five-minute habit is small enough to do when you are ill, late or out of sorts, and doing it on those days is exactly what makes it stick. Behaviour scientist B.J. Fogg builds an entire method around this idea, and it is the backbone of this workbook.

Anchors beat willpower. Researchers describe "implementation intentions": specific if-then plans such as *"After I pour my coffee, I will take three slow breaths."* Studies reviewed by Peter Gollwitzer suggest that deciding in advance when and where you will act makes follow-through more likely than a general intention to "do better."

Habits take time, and missing a day is fine. In a well-known study by Phillippa Lally and colleagues, the time for a new behaviour to feel automatic varied widely between people and behaviours, from a few weeks to many months, with a typical figure of around two months. Missing the occasional day did not derail the process. That is why this workbook asks you to **never miss twice**, instead of never missing.

Recalling beats re-reading. Studies on "test-enhanced learning" by Henry Roediger and Jeffrey Karpicke found that trying to remember something strengthens memory more than reading it again. Spreading practice across days, rather than cramming, helps too. Weeks four and five put these findings to work in daily life.

Your environment is part of your memory. Hooks for keys, a basket by the door and a visible planner all move the job of remembering out of your head and into the room. That is not cheating. It is how skilled people work.

How To Read The Rest Of This Book

Do the small thing. Tick the box. Notice what changes. Adjust the plan, not yourself.

The six weeks are a starting point. The aim is a handful of habits that fit your life and are still running a year from now.

My Notes

Part One: Everyday Memory Questionnaire

Your Baseline Self-Check

Choose the number that best describes the **last month**. This is not a test or a diagnosis. It simply gives you a starting point to compare against in week six. Be honest rather than flattering: nobody sees this but you.

0 = Never **1** = Sometimes **2** = Often **3** = Very Often

#	In the last month...	Score
1	I walk into a room and forget why I went there.	
2	I misplace keys, my phone, glasses or my wallet.	
3	I forget a person's name soon after hearing it.	
4	I struggle to find a familiar word in conversation.	
5	I forget a task or appointment I meant to do.	
6	I have to re-read or replay something because my attention drifted.	
7	After an interruption I lose track of what I was doing.	
8	I wonder whether I have done something (locked the door, sent the email).	
9	I leave the house without something I meant to take.	
10	I open an app or a browser tab and forget what I wanted.	
11	I repeat a story or question to the same person.	
12	I feel mentally foggy by mid-afternoon.	

My total (0 to 36): _____ Date: _____

A higher number only shows where there is more room to help yourself. It cannot tell you why slips happen. Keep it for comparison.

Part Two: Quick Recall Tasks

Your Baseline Self-Check

These two short tasks give you a feel for your recall today. They are informal and for comparison with yourself only.

Task A: The Ten-Word List

Step 1. Read these ten words once, slowly, about two seconds each. Do not write them down or repeat them aloud.

lantern · orchard · button · ribbon · harbour · pillow · bridge · copper · window · sparrow

Step 2. Look away. Spend five minutes on something else, such as making a drink or answering Task B. **Step 3.** Without looking back, write as many words as you can below.

Words I remembered

Words recalled: _____ out of 10 Date: _____

Task B: Yesterday In Order

Without checking your phone or calendar, list the main things you did yesterday, in order, with approximate times. Aim for at least six items.

Yesterday, from morning to night

Items recalled: _____ How easy was it? 1 = very hard, 5 = very easy: _____

A Page To Take Seriously

When To Talk To A Doctor

Everyday slips are common, and this programme is built for them. But some changes deserve a proper check-up, and it is always better to ask than to wonder. Please arrange a medical appointment if you notice any of the following:

- Memory or thinking has changed **suddenly**, or has been getting steadily worse over weeks or months.
- Slips are getting in the way of daily life: missed bills, getting lost on familiar routes, trouble with tasks you have always done, or repeated questions that others notice.
- Friends, family or colleagues have noticed changes in your memory, mood or behaviour, or you have new confusion or difficulty following conversations.
- You are very low, anxious, exhausted, or not coping, or you suspect your sleep is badly disturbed (loud snoring, pauses in breathing, extreme daytime sleepiness).
- You have recently started or changed a medication, have a health condition that could affect thinking, or are simply worried.

> **Urgent Symptoms**
>
> Seek urgent medical help immediately for sudden severe headache, weakness or numbness on one side, slurred speech, sudden vision loss, or sudden confusion. Do not wait to finish a workbook.

Prepare For Your Appointment

What has changed, and since when?

Medications and supplements I take

Sleep, alcohol, stress and mood in recent weeks

Questions I want to ask

Step One: Find Your Anchors

Build Your Routine Map

An **anchor** is a steady moment in your day that already happens without you thinking about it. The best anchors are specific, frequent and tied to a place. “In the morning” is vague. “After I switch on the kettle” is an anchor.

Tick every anchor that happens on most days, then circle the five you trust most.

- [ ] I switch off my alarm
- [ ] I make the first drink of the day
- [ ] I brush my teeth (morning)
- [ ] I start the car or board transport
- [ ] I arrive at work or sit at my desk
- [ ] I stop for lunch
- [ ] I make an afternoon drink
- [ ] I finish work, close the laptop or lock up
- [ ] I begin cooking dinner
- [ ] I finish the evening routine
- [ ] I plug in my phone to charge
- [ ] I brush my teeth (evening)

Other anchors I have

Choosing Well

Good anchors are things you do **every day, in the same place,** and that are not easily skipped. A coffee break that happens only on office days is a weaker anchor than brushing your teeth.

My five strongest anchors, and when each happens

Step Two: Your Daily Rhythm

Build Your Routine Map

Sketch a typical weekday. Note when your energy is highest and lowest, when interruptions strike and where five quiet minutes could fit. Different habits suit different parts of the day: calm, low-effort habits (like the wind-down) belong to evenings, and focus habits belong to when you are sharpest.

Time of Day	What I Usually Do	Energy (1-5)	Free Five Minutes?
Wake-up			
Early morning			
Mid-morning			
Lunchtime			
Early afternoon			
Late afternoon			
Early evening			
Late evening			
Bedtime			

My sharpest time of day, and why I think so

My most distracted time of day, and why

The three biggest interruptions in my day

Step Three: Your Reasons And Your Support

Build Your Routine Map

Change is easier when the reason belongs to you. Spend a few minutes on these questions, then come back to this page whenever motivation dips.

1. What do I most want my memory to do for me? (be specific: names at work, no more lost keys, reading without drifting)

2. What will I notice in daily life if this goes well?

3. What usually gets in the way when I try a new habit?

4. What will I do about that, in plain if-then words? *If ____ happens, then I will ____.*

5. Who can I tell about this, and what would help from them?

My Commitment

I will give this six weeks, at five minutes a day. When I miss a day I will simply start again the next day.

Signed: _____ Date: _____

My Notes

Your Habit: The Five-Minute Wind-Down

Week 1: Sleep

Give today's memories the best chance to settle overnight.

Your Five-Minute Recipe

1. Right after your evening anchor, put your phone on charge **out of arm's reach** of the bed.
2. Write tomorrow's top three tasks and anything circling in your head on one page (the **brain dump**).
3. Dim the lights and take six slow breaths, longer out than in.
4. Tick today's box and say, "Done. Tomorrow is planned."

Get Ready This Week

- [ ] Choose a charging spot away from the bed
- [ ] Put a notepad and pen where you will see them in the evening
- [ ] Decide a rough lights-out time (a range is fine)
- [ ] Check your lamp or lighting can be dimmed
- [ ] Tell one person you are starting

My anchor for this habit

When and where I will do it

How I will celebrate when I finish

This Week In One Line

Small, steady, specific. If it takes more than five minutes, shrink it.

My Notes

Week 1: Learn

Why It Works

Sleep is one of the best-supported links between a good day and a good memory. During sleep the brain replays and reorganises what you took in, helping new information settle into long-term memory. A review by Susanne Diekelmann and Jan Born describes this role of sleep in detail.

Short or broken sleep also hits **attention** the next day, and attention is the doorway through which everything enters memory. Many midlife slips on a bad-sleep day are really attention slips.

A busy mind at bedtime makes sleep harder. In a small sleep-lab study of healthy young adults, Michael Scullin and colleagues found that those who spent five minutes writing a to-do list fell asleep faster than those who wrote about tasks already done. The finding comes from one small study and needs more research, but offloading tomorrow onto paper costs five minutes and is worth a try.

> **Key Idea**
> Aim for a consistent wake-up time, a dark and cool room, and caffeine early in the day. Alcohol can feel like it helps you drift off but tends to disturb sleep later in the night.

One thing I want to try from this page

One thing I am unsure about

My Notes

Week 1: Learn

Common Traps And Fixes

Most people hit at least one of these in the first week. Spot yours in advance, and decide what you will do about it.

Trap	A Simple Fix
I scroll in bed "just for a minute".	Charge the phone in another room, and buy a cheap alarm clock.
My mind races at night.	Extend the brain dump to a second page, and add a "worry window" earlier in the evening.
Bedtime keeps drifting later.	Set an alarm for the *start* of the wind-down, not bedtime.
I share a room with a partner or children.	Do the wind-down in the living room, then move quietly.
I snore, wake unrefreshed or feel sleepy in the day.	Mention it to your doctor. Sleep problems are common and treatable.

The trap I am most likely to fall into

My if-then answer to it *If ____, then I will ____.*

My Notes

Week 1: Plan

Make It Yours: Planner

Write your plan in the sentences below. The more specific you are, the more likely you are to follow through.

My Habit Sentence

After I _____ (anchor),

I will _____ (habit) for five minutes.

Make it obvious: how will I see or hear my cue?

Make it easy: what will I prepare the night before?

Make it satisfying: how will I celebrate?

Obstacle 1 and my if-then plan *If ____, then I will ____.*

Obstacle 2 and my if-then plan *If ____, then I will ____.*

My two-minute backup version

Who will I tell, and how will they help?

My Notes

Week 1: Practice A

My Sleep Snapshot

For seven nights, note the basics. You are looking for patterns, not perfection.

Night	Lights Out	Woke Up	Wake-Ups	Last Caffeine	Screens Off
Mon					
Tue					
Wed					
Thu					
Fri					
Sat					
Sun					

What pattern do I notice?

Week 1: Practice B

Wind-Down Design

Pick the cues that will tell your body that the day is ending. Tick three or more and add your own.

- [ ] Phone on charge outside the bedroom
- [ ] Lights dimmed 30 minutes before bed
- [ ] Warm shower or wash
- [ ] Same pyjamas or a calming ritual
- [ ] Reading something light (paper or e-ink)
- [ ] Gentle stretching
- [ ] Herbal tea or warm water (no caffeine)
- [ ] Quiet music or a podcast with a timer

My wind-down in five minutes, step by step

Week 1: Practice C

The Brain Dump Page

Practise the core skill. Empty your head onto the page, then choose what matters tomorrow.

Tasks I must do

Things worrying me

Ideas to keep

Reminders for others

My top three for tomorrow

Week 1: Practice D

A One-Week Mini-Experiment

Pick one small sleep change for seven days and track the result. Rate each morning from 1 (foggy) to 5 (clear).

The change I will try

My prediction

Day	Morning Clarity (1-5)	Notes
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

What I learned

Daily Log: Week 1

Day 1 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Hours slept (approx.)

Time I started the wind-down

Energy today *Low* (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) *High*

Focus today *Scattered* (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 2 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Hours slept (approx.)

Time I started the wind-down

Energy today *Low* (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) *High*

Focus today *Scattered* (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 1

Day 3 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Hours slept (approx.)

Time I started the wind-down

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 4 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Hours slept (approx.)

Time I started the wind-down

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 1

Day 5 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Hours slept (approx.)

Time I started the wind-down

Energy today *Low* (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) *High*

Focus today *Scattered* (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 6 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Hours slept (approx.)

Time I started the wind-down

Energy today *Low* (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) *High*

Focus today *Scattered* (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 1

Day 7 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Hours slept (approx.)

Time I started the wind-down

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

End-Of-Week Check

How easy was this habit this week? *Hard* 1 2 3 4 5 *Easy*

How useful did it feel? *Not much* 1 2 3 4 5 *Very*

How confident am I about continuing? *Not yet* 1 2 3 4 5 *Very*

What I notice about myself after a week

Week 1: Reflect

Weekly Review

Take ten minutes to look back. The point is not to judge, but to learn what to adjust.

Days I did my habit (out of 7)

What worked best this week?

What got in the way?

Memory slips this week, and any pattern I notice

Decide

- [ ] **Keep** it as it is
- [ ] **Tweak** it (what will I change?)
- [ ] **Swap** it for something easier

My plan for next week

A note to my future self

- [ ] **Week complete. I celebrated.**

My Notes

Week 1: Reflect

Questions And Notes

Question	Answer
What if I miss a night?	Just do it the next night. One miss changes nothing, and two misses in a row is the signal to restart gently.
I work shifts. Does this still work?	Yes. Anchor it to the end of your shift or before your main sleep, wherever that falls.
Do I need eight hours?	Needs vary. Aim for what leaves you alert most days and discuss persistent problems with a doctor.

Notes, doodles and questions for later

Your Habit: One Thing, Out Loud

Week 2: Attention

Memory starts with paying attention. Make it deliberate for five minutes.

Your Five-Minute Recipe

1. After your anchor, set a five-minute timer and choose **one** task.
2. Phone face-down or in another room, one window open, notifications off.
3. Work only on that task until the timer ends.
4. Once a day, **say aloud** where you put something down: “Keys on the hook.” Tick the box.

Get Ready This Week

- [ ] Choose your daily task type (email, reading, planning, admin)
- [ ] Find a timer that is not on your phone, or use airplane mode
- [ ] Pick one “home” for each item you often lose
- [ ] Silence non-essential notifications
- [ ] Tell colleagues or family you may be offline for five minutes

My anchor for this habit

When and where I will do it

How I will celebrate when I finish

This Week In One Line

Small, steady, specific. If it takes more than five minutes, shrink it.

My Notes

Week 2: Learn

Why It Works

Most everyday forgetting is not storage failure: the information never fully registered. Daniel Schacter calls this absent-mindedness. If your mind is on tomorrow's meeting while you put your glasses down, there is nothing to retrieve later.

Splitting attention has a cost. Eyal Ophir, Clifford Nass and Anthony Wagner found that people who habitually juggle several media streams did worse at filtering out distractions than those who did not. You do not need to give up your phone, only to give yourself short stretches where one thing has your attention.

Saying it aloud works because it forces a moment of attention and adds a second route into memory (hearing yourself). Pair it with a glance at the object and its place, and you have built a mini-memory in two seconds.

> **Key Idea**
> Start with five minutes. Attention, like a muscle, responds to short, regular effort better than to occasional marathons.

One thing I want to try from this page

One thing I am unsure about

My Notes

Week 2: Learn

Common Traps And Fixes

Most people hit at least one of these in the first week. Spot yours in advance, and decide what you will do about it.

Trap	A Simple Fix
The timer feels pointless; five minutes is nothing.	Five minutes is the point. Make the habit unmissable, and lengthen later if you wish.
Someone interrupts me.	Say, “Give me five minutes.” Most requests can wait that long.
I keep checking my phone.	Put it in another room. Out of sight reduces temptation more than willpower does.
I forget to say it aloud.	Attach it to one specific object, such as the front-door keys.
I feel silly speaking to myself.	A whisper counts. You are building a habit, not giving a performance.

The trap I am most likely to fall into

My if-then answer to it *If ____, then I will ____.*

My Notes

Week 2: Plan

Make It Yours: Planner

Write your plan in the sentences below. The more specific you are, the more likely you are to follow through.

My Habit Sentence

After I _____ (anchor),

I will _____ (habit) for five minutes.

Make it obvious: how will I see or hear my cue?

Make it easy: what will I prepare the night before?

Make it satisfying: how will I celebrate?

Obstacle 1 and my if-then plan *If ____, then I will ____.*

Obstacle 2 and my if-then plan *If ____, then I will ____.*

My two-minute backup version

Who will I tell, and how will they help?

My Notes

Week 2: Practice A

My Distraction Audit

For one day, note each time your attention is pulled away. Patterns reveal easy wins.

Time	What Interrupted Me	Source	Avoidable?

My three biggest distractions, and what I will change

Week 2: Practice B

Place It, Say It, Picture It

Choose five items you often misplace. Give each a permanent home, and practise placing them with attention.

Item	Its Home	Placed Aloud?	Found It Later?

What I notice when I place things on purpose

Week 2: Practice C

Five-Minute Focus Sprints

Log seven sprints. Rate your focus from 1 (scattered) to 5 (locked in).

Day	Task	Focus 1-5	Interruptions
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

What helped me focus most?

Week 2: Practice D

Notification And Phone Reset

Tick what you will do this week, then note how it felt.

- [ ] Turn off non-essential notifications
- [ ] Move distracting apps off the first screen
- [ ] Keep the phone out of reach during sprints
- [ ] Set grey-scale or do-not-disturb at set times
- [ ] Use a physical alarm clock
- [ ] Create a charging spot away from the desk
- [ ] Agree a “reply by” time with colleagues
- [ ] Close unneeded browser tabs at day’s end

How did it feel, and what changed?

Daily Log: Week 2

Day 1 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Items I placed aloud today

Sprint focus rating (1-5)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 2 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Items I placed aloud today

Sprint focus rating (1-5)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 2

Day 3 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Items I placed aloud today

Sprint focus rating (1-5)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 4 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
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Daily Log: Week 2

Day 5 Date: _____

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Items I placed aloud today

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Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 2

Day 7 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Items I placed aloud today

Sprint focus rating (1-5)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

End-Of-Week Check

How easy was this habit this week? *Hard* 1 2 3 4 5 *Easy*

How useful did it feel? *Not much* 1 2 3 4 5 *Very*

How confident am I about continuing? *Not yet* 1 2 3 4 5 *Very*

What I notice about myself after a week

Week 2: Reflect

Weekly Review

Take ten minutes to look back. The point is not to judge, but to learn what to adjust.

Days I did my habit (out of 7)

What worked best this week?

What got in the way?

Memory slips this week, and any pattern I notice

Decide

- [ ] **Keep** it as it is
- [ ] **Tweak** it (what will I change?)
- [ ] **Swap** it for something easier

My plan for next week

A note to my future self

- [ ] **Week complete. I celebrated.**

My Notes

Week 2: Reflect

Questions And Notes

Question	Answer
Do I have to use a timer?	A timer makes the five minutes concrete. If you hate them, use a song, or the boil of a kettle.
What if my job is all interruptions?	Choose a different anchor, such as arriving home, and keep to five minutes.
Is it OK to look at my phone for calls?	Absolutely. Set the phone so key people can reach you, and keep everything else quiet.

Notes, doodles and questions for later

Your Habit: The Five-Minute Movement Snack

Week 3: Movement

Wake the brain by moving the body, a few minutes at a time.

Your Five-Minute Recipe

1. After your anchor, **move for five minutes**: brisk walk, stairs, marching on the spot, or chair-based movement.
2. As you move, recall your plan for the day, or yesterday, in order, in your head.
3. Notice how you feel afterwards.
4. Tick the box and move on.

Get Ready This Week

- [ ] Check you are comfortable with the activity (ask your doctor if unsure)
- [ ] Choose footwear and a safe, easy route
- [ ] Pick an indoor option for bad weather
- [ ] Decide on one chair-based alternative
- [ ] Put your anchor and your route in the planner

My anchor for this habit

When and where I will do it

How I will celebrate when I finish

This Week In One Line

Small, steady, specific. If it takes more than five minutes, shrink it.

My Notes

Week 3: Learn

Why It Works

Regular physical activity is linked with better cognitive function and overall brain health, and it improves sleep and mood, which in turn help memory. Even brief bouts matter: a meta-analysis by Yu-Kai Chang and colleagues found small positive effects of a single session of exercise on cognitive performance.

You do not need a gym. Five minutes of brisk movement after a long sit raises heart rate, shifts attention and breaks a stuck mood. It is also a perfect anchor for recall: thinking through the day while you walk links movement and memory practice into one habit.

Choose movement you can do on your **worst** day. A walk to the end of the street counts. So does standing up and marching in place during a call. If you want to do more, wonderful, but never less than the five-minute floor.

> **Key Idea**
> People with joint, heart, balance or other health conditions should adapt movements and check with a health professional. The aim is to feel pleasantly warmed up, not exhausted.

One thing I want to try from this page

One thing I am unsure about

My Notes

Week 3: Learn

Common Traps And Fixes

Most people hit at least one of these in the first week. Spot yours in advance, and decide what you will do about it.

Trap	A Simple Fix
I do not have time.	Five minutes fits almost anywhere. Walk while you wait for the kettle, or take the longer route to the car.
It is raining, or I am in the office.	Use stairs, a corridor or marching on the spot.
I am out of shape.	Begin at an easy pace. Comfortable and consistent beats fast and abandoned.
I feel embarrassed.	Choose a private spot, or bring a friend. Some of the best habits are shared.
I have pain or a health condition.	Adapt the movement and take advice from your doctor or physiotherapist.

The trap I am most likely to fall into

My if-then answer to it *If ____, then I will ____.*

My Notes

Week 3: Plan

Make It Yours: Planner

Write your plan in the sentences below. The more specific you are, the more likely you are to follow through.

My Habit Sentence

After I _____ (anchor),

I will _____ (habit) for five minutes.

Make it obvious: how will I see or hear my cue?

Make it easy: what will I prepare the night before?

Make it satisfying: how will I celebrate?

Obstacle 1 and my if-then plan *If ____, then I will ____.*

Obstacle 2 and my if-then plan *If ____, then I will ____.*

My two-minute backup version

Who will I tell, and how will they help?

My Notes

Week 3: Practice A

My Movement Menu

Tick five movement snacks you could do. Add your own at the bottom.

- [ ] Brisk walk around the block
- [ ] Stairs up and down twice
- [ ] Marching on the spot
- [ ] Gentle stretching
- [ ] Chair squats or sit-to-stand
- [ ] Dancing to one song
- [ ] Walking while on a call
- [ ] Carrying the shopping the long way
- [ ] Gardening or housework with intent
- [ ] Chair-based arm and leg movements

My top three, and where each fits in my day

Week 3: Practice B

Walk And Recall

On a walk, recall yesterday in order, aloud or in your head. Afterwards, jot down what you remembered and check it.

What I remembered about yesterday

What I missed, then checked

How I felt afterwards

My Notes

Week 3: Practice C

Energy And Focus Tracker

Rate before and after a movement snack on six different days. Look for a pattern.

Day	Energy Before	Energy After	Focus Before	Focus After

What changes do I notice, if any?

Week 3: Practice D

Stack Builder

Write your movement snack into an if-then plan and design a backup for bad weather or low energy.

After I (anchor)…

I will move by (activity)…

For five minutes in (place)…

On a wet or low-energy day I will…

Who could join me, and how will I ask?

Daily Log: Week 3

Day 1 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Minutes I moved today

Energy after moving (1-5)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 2 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Minutes I moved today

Energy after moving (1-5)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 3

Day 3 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Minutes I moved today

Energy after moving (1-5)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 4 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Minutes I moved today

Energy after moving (1-5)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 3

Day 5 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Minutes I moved today

Energy after moving (1-5)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 6 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Minutes I moved today

Energy after moving (1-5)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

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Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 3

Day 7 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Minutes I moved today

Energy after moving (1-5)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

End-Of-Week Check

How easy was this habit this week? *Hard* 1 2 3 4 5 *Easy*

How useful did it feel? *Not much* 1 2 3 4 5 *Very*

How confident am I about continuing? *Not yet* 1 2 3 4 5 *Very*

What I notice about myself after a week

Week 3: Reflect

Weekly Review

Take ten minutes to look back. The point is not to judge, but to learn what to adjust.

Days I did my habit (out of 7)

What worked best this week?

What got in the way?

Memory slips this week, and any pattern I notice

Decide

- ☐ **Keep** it as it is
- ☐ **Tweak** it (what will I change?)
- ☐ **Swap** it for something easier

My plan for next week

A note to my future self

- ☐ **Week complete. I celebrated.**

My Notes

Week 3: Reflect

Questions And Notes

Question	Answer
Does five minutes really count?	Yes. It builds the habit, and many people find they naturally do more once they have started.
What if I already exercise?	Great. Keep it, and add this snack as a memory cue after a long sit.
What about recovery days?	Do a gentle version: stretching or an easy stroll.

Notes, doodles and questions for later

Your Habit: Recall Before You Check

Week 4: Retrieval

Strengthen what you know by pulling it out, not by looking it up.

Your Five-Minute Recipe

1. After your anchor, **close the notes** and write down what you remember: yesterday, today's plan, or a person's name.
2. Then check and correct what you missed.
3. Once or twice a week, use your recall cards (names or facts) on a 1-3-7-day schedule.
4. Tick the box and celebrate the effort, not just the score.

Get Ready This Week

- [ ] Choose your daily recall topic (yesterday, tomorrow, a name, a fact)
- [ ] Prepare a pack of index cards or use the planner pages
- [ ] Make a list of five people or facts you want to remember
- [ ] Set a recurring reminder for your review days
- [ ] Decide a place to keep your cards

My anchor for this habit

When and where I will do it

How I will celebrate when I finish

This Week In One Line

Small, steady, specific. If it takes more than five minutes, shrink it.

My Notes

Week 4: Learn

Why It Works

Re-reading feels productive but is surprisingly weak. In a classic study, Henry Roediger and Jeffrey Karpicke found that people who practised **retrieving** information remembered more a week later than those who simply studied it again. The effort of pulling something out is what strengthens it.

Spacing helps too. A large review by Nicholas Cepeda and colleagues found that spreading practice across days generally beats cramming it all together. A simple pattern is to review a new item after one day, three days and seven days.

This week is not about memory tricks. It is about practising the real thing: “What was her name? What is on today’s list?” Struggling a little before you look is a feature, not a flaw.

> **Key Idea**
> Be kind to yourself. If you forget something during practice, you are exactly where the benefit happens. Check the answer, say it aloud once, and move on.

One thing I want to try from this page

One thing I am unsure about

My Notes

Week 4: Learn

Common Traps And Fixes

Most people hit at least one of these in the first week. Spot yours in advance, and decide what you will do about it.

Trap	A Simple Fix
I get frustrated when I cannot recall.	That struggle is the useful bit. Take a breath, check, and try again tomorrow.
I forget to review.	Link review days to anchors, such as Monday coffee and Thursday lunch.
I do not know what to practise.	Start with yesterday's events and one name a day.
The cards pile up.	Retire cards you get right three times in a row.
Someone tests me and I panic.	Practise in private first, then in low-pressure settings.

The trap I am most likely to fall into

My if-then answer to it *If ____, then I will ____.*

My Notes

Week 4: Plan

Make It Yours: Planner

Write your plan in the sentences below. The more specific you are, the more likely you are to follow through.

My Habit Sentence

After I _____ (anchor),

I will _____ (habit) for five minutes.

Make it obvious: how will I see or hear my cue?

Make it easy: what will I prepare the night before?

Make it satisfying: how will I celebrate?

Obstacle 1 and my if-then plan *If ____, then I will ____.*

Obstacle 2 and my if-then plan *If ____, then I will ____.*

My two-minute backup version

Who will I tell, and how will they help?

My Notes

Week 4: Practice A

Daily Recall Page

Without checking, write what you remember from yesterday, then compare with your calendar or messages.

Yesterday I…

People I spoke to

Things I meant to do and did

Things I meant to do and missed

My Notes

Week 4: Practice B

Names And Faces Cards

List five people whose names you want to hold on to. Add a link: where you met, what they do, an image that fits.

Name	Where Met	My Link or Image	Review Dates

How will I use their name this week?

Week 4: Practice C

Spaced Recall Practice

Write five facts you want to remember. Tick each review as you do it.

Fact To Remember	Day 1	Day 3	Day 7

Which facts stuck? Which slipped?

Week 4: Practice D

Teach It Back

Explain something you learned this week to a friend or write it in your own words. Teaching is a strong form of recall.

What I learned

How I would explain it simply

Where I stumbled

Who I explained it to

My Notes

Daily Log: Week 4

Day 1 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

What I recalled without checking

Review I did today (cards, names or facts)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 2 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

What I recalled without checking

Review I did today (cards, names or facts)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 4

Day 3 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

What I recalled without checking

Review I did today (cards, names or facts)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

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Day 4 Date: _____

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What I recalled without checking

Review I did today (cards, names or facts)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 4

Day 5 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

What I recalled without checking

Review I did today (cards, names or facts)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 6 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

What I recalled without checking

Review I did today (cards, names or facts)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 4

Day 7 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

What I recalled without checking

Review I did today (cards, names or facts)

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

End-Of-Week Check

How easy was this habit this week? *Hard* 1 2 3 4 5 *Easy*

How useful did it feel? *Not much* 1 2 3 4 5 *Very*

How confident am I about continuing? *Not yet* 1 2 3 4 5 *Very*

What I notice about myself after a week

Week 4: Reflect

Weekly Review

Take ten minutes to look back. The point is not to judge, but to learn what to adjust.

Days I did my habit (out of 7)

What worked best this week?

What got in the way?

Memory slips this week, and any pattern I notice

Decide

- ☐ **Keep** it as it is
- ☐ **Tweak** it (what will I change?)
- ☐ **Swap** it for something easier

My plan for next week

A note to my future self

- ☐ **Week complete. I celebrated.**

My Notes

Week 4: Reflect

Questions And Notes

Question	Answer
What counts as practice?	Anything where you try to remember before you look: names, plans, facts, the shopping list.
Should I keep a streak?	Keep a record, but do not worry about perfect streaks. Return quickly after a gap.
What if I forget everything?	Then start with one small item, and expect gradual improvement.

Notes, doodles and questions for later

Your Habit: The Three-Second Tag

Week 5: Encoding

Tag what matters in the moment, so you can find it later.

Your Five-Minute Recipe

1. When you hear a name, park the car or put something down, **pause for three seconds**.
2. **Notice** it with your full attention, **say** it (aloud or silently) and **link** it to a picture, place or meaning.
3. Use the name or fact again within a minute, or write one word in your notebook.
4. At day's end tick the box if you tagged at least one thing.

Get Ready This Week

- [ ] Carry a small notebook or use a notes app
- [ ] Choose three situations to tag (new names, parking, where you put things)
- [ ] Practise with three people this week
- [ ] Review last week's recall cards
- [ ] Invent a silly phrase to remind yourself: "Notice, say, link."

My anchor for this habit

When and where I will do it

How I will celebrate when I finish

This Week In One Line

Small, steady, specific. If it takes more than five minutes, shrink it.

My Notes

Week 5: Learn

Why It Works

Memory depends on how deeply you process something when you first meet it. Fergus Craik and Robert Lockhart showed that attending to meaning and connections leads to better remembering than skimming the surface. A name heard once is gone. A name noticed, repeated and linked to a picture is far more likely to stay.

Tags are quick hooks: a vivid image (“Rose, who has the red scarf”), a link to someone you already know, or a location (“Level 3, near the lift”). The more personal and unusual the link, the better it tends to work.

Chunking helps with numbers: 0207 946 0123 is easier than ten separate digits. **Stories** help with lists: link each item to the next in a short, silly story.

> **Key Idea**
> None of this requires a special gift. It takes three seconds of attention, a link and a repeat, ideally within a minute of meeting the information.

One thing I want to try from this page

One thing I am unsure about

My Notes

Week 5: Learn

Common Traps And Fixes

Most people hit at least one of these in the first week. Spot yours in advance, and decide what you will do about it.

Trap	A Simple Fix
I miss the name because I am nervous.	Ask them to repeat it: “Sorry, I want to get your name right.”
My links feel silly.	They are meant to be. Silly and personal beats sensible and forgettable.
I forget to pause.	Tie it to one situation per day, such as a new colleague or parking the car.
I use the name and still forget.	Add a written one-word tag in your phone, and review it at day’s end.
Crowded rooms overwhelm me.	Aim for just one or two names. Quality beats quantity.

The trap I am most likely to fall into

My if-then answer to it *If ____, then I will ____.*

My Notes

Week 5: Plan

Make It Yours: Planner

Write your plan in the sentences below. The more specific you are, the more likely you are to follow through.

My Habit Sentence

After I _____ (anchor),

I will _____ (habit) for five minutes.

Make it obvious: how will I see or hear my cue?

Make it easy: what will I prepare the night before?

Make it satisfying: how will I celebrate?

Obstacle 1 and my if-then plan *If ____, then I will ____.*

Obstacle 2 and my if-then plan *If ____, then I will ____.*

My two-minute backup version

Who will I tell, and how will they help?

My Notes

Week 5: Practice A

The Name Game

Practise on people you will meet this week. Build a link for each name.

Name	What I Noticed	My Link or Picture	Used It Aloud?

Which link worked best, and why?

Week 5: Practice B

Chunk It

Turn long numbers and codes into chunks you can hold. Write three real examples from your life.

A number I need (phone, code)

How I chunked it

A date or list I need

How I linked it

My Notes

Week 5: Practice C

Story Link

Memorise a list of ten items by linking each to the next in a short, vivid story. Use the shopping list or ten errands.

My ten items

My story that links them

How many I recalled later (tonight)

How many I recalled tomorrow

My Notes

Week 5: Practice D

Parking And Place Tags

Practise tagging real-world locations: the car, the bike, the umbrella, the passport.

Item	Where I Put It	My Tag	Found It?

What have I learned about myself as a placer of things?

Daily Log: Week 5

Day 1 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Names or items I tagged today

Which tag worked best?

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 2 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Names or items I tagged today

Which tag worked best?

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 5

Day 3 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Names or items I tagged today

Which tag worked best?

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 4 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Names or items I tagged today

Which tag worked best?

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 5

Day 5 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Names or items I tagged today

Which tag worked best?

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 6 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Names or items I tagged today

Which tag worked best?

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 5

Day 7 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Names or items I tagged today

Which tag worked best?

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

End-Of-Week Check

How easy was this habit this week? *Hard* 1 2 3 4 5 *Easy*

How useful did it feel? *Not much* 1 2 3 4 5 *Very*

How confident am I about continuing? *Not yet* 1 2 3 4 5 *Very*

What I notice about myself after a week

Week 5: Reflect

Weekly Review

Take ten minutes to look back. The point is not to judge, but to learn what to adjust.

Days I did my habit (out of 7)

What worked best this week?

What got in the way?

Memory slips this week, and any pattern I notice

Decide

- ☐ **Keep** it as it is
- ☐ **Tweak** it (what will I change?)
- ☐ **Swap** it for something easier

My plan for next week

A note to my future self

- ☐ **Week complete. I celebrated.**

My Notes

Week 5: Reflect

Questions And Notes

Question	Answer
Is it rude to ask someone to repeat their name?	Not at all. Most people appreciate the effort.
Does this work for numbers?	Chunking helps. Linking numbers to dates or images you know helps further.
Can I just write everything down?	Notes are great. Tagging helps when you cannot, and it makes your notes more useful.

Notes, doodles and questions for later

Your Habit: The Daily Five

Week 6: Lock-In

Stack your habits into a rhythm that survives real life.

Your Five-Minute Recipe

1. After your main anchor, do **one** of your five habits for five minutes: wind-down, one-thing, movement, recall, tag.
2. Rotate by day, or choose the one you need most today.
3. Keep a backup plan for disrupted days.
4. **Never miss twice.** If you miss, return the next day.

Get Ready This Week

- [ ] Review your five habits and choose a rotation
- [ ] Mark your anchors for each habit in the planner
- [ ] List events that could disrupt you (travel, illness, deadlines)
- [ ] Prepare backup plans
- [ ] Tell someone how you want to be supported

My anchor for this habit

When and where I will do it

How I will celebrate when I finish

This Week In One Line

Small, steady, specific. If it takes more than five minutes, shrink it.

My Notes

Week 6: Learn

Why It Works

This week turns practice into routine. Phillippa Lally and colleagues found that the time for a new behaviour to become automatic varied widely, from a few weeks to many months, and that missing the odd day did not derail the process. What mattered was getting back to it.

That is why the Daily Five is flexible. Some days you will do the wind-down, other days a focus sprint, a walk, a recall page or a tag. What matters is that **something** happens at your anchor each day.

Habits are most fragile during disruption: holidays, illness, new schedules. Decide now what the smallest possible version looks like ("two minutes counts") and write it down. Deciding in advance is far easier than deciding in the moment.

> **Key Idea**
> Finally, look at the evidence of change. Compare your baseline with your week-six scores, but also notice the small wins: fewer lost keys, an easier day, a name remembered.

One thing I want to try from this page

One thing I am unsure about

My Notes

Week 6: Learn

Common Traps And Fixes

Most people hit at least one of these in the first week. Spot yours in advance, and decide what you will do about it.

Trap	A Simple Fix
I am tempted to do all five every day.	Resist. Five minutes of one habit is the floor. More is a bonus, not the rule.
Life got busy and I missed three days.	Do the two-minute version today. Restarting beats waiting for a perfect Monday.
I feel bored with it.	Swap a habit from the menu at the back of the book.
I lost motivation.	Re-read your reasons on the Routine Map page.
I feel no different.	Check your final self-check and slip log. Progress can be quiet.

The trap I am most likely to fall into

My if-then answer to it *If ____, then I will ____.*

My Notes

Week 6: Plan

Make It Yours: Planner

Write your plan in the sentences below. The more specific you are, the more likely you are to follow through.

My Habit Sentence

After I _____ (anchor),

I will _____ (habit) for five minutes.

Make it obvious: how will I see or hear my cue?

Make it easy: what will I prepare the night before?

Make it satisfying: how will I celebrate?

Obstacle 1 and my if-then plan *If ____, then I will ____.*

Obstacle 2 and my if-then plan *If ____, then I will ____.*

My two-minute backup version

Who will I tell, and how will they help?

My Notes

Week 6: Practice A

Build My Daily Five

Choose which habit goes with which day, and the anchor you will use.

Day	Habit	Anchor	Backup
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

What makes this plan realistic for my life?

Week 6: Practice B

Disruption Plan

Write if-then plans for the situations most likely to throw you.

If I am travelling, then I will…

If I am ill or exhausted, then I will…

If work is overwhelming, then I will…

If I miss two days, then I will…

My Notes

Week 6: Practice C

Habit Strength Check

Rate each statement from 1 (not at all) to 5 (completely) about your main habit.

I do it without having to think about it *Not at all* 1 2 3 4 5 *Completely*

I would feel odd if I skipped it *Not at all* 1 2 3 4 5 *Completely*

I do it even when I am busy or tired *Not at all* 1 2 3 4 5 *Completely*

It feels like part of my day *Not at all* 1 2 3 4 5 *Completely*

I would notice if I stopped *Not at all* 1 2 3 4 5 *Completely*

My strongest habit so far and why

Week 6: Practice D

My Proof Page

List concrete signs of change, however small, so you can see progress.

Things I now do that I did not before

Slips that happen less often

Moments I felt sharper

What I am proud of

My Notes

Daily Log: Week 6

Day 1 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Habit I did today

Any slip, and what I learned

Energy today *Low* (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) *High*

Focus today *Scattered* (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 2 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Habit I did today

Any slip, and what I learned

Energy today *Low* (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) *High*

Focus today *Scattered* (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 6

Day 3 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Habit I did today

Any slip, and what I learned

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 4 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Habit I did today

Any slip, and what I learned

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 6

Day 5 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Habit I did today

Any slip, and what I learned

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Day 6 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Habit I did today

Any slip, and what I learned

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

Daily Log: Week 6

Day 7 Date: _____

- [ ] I used my anchor today
- [ ] I did my five-minute habit

Habit I did today

Any slip, and what I learned

Energy today *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Focus today *Scattered* 1 2 3 4 5 *Sharp*

Memory slip today (what happened?)

Something I recalled without checking

My tiny win

End-Of-Week Check

How easy was this habit this week? *Hard* 1 2 3 4 5 *Easy*

How useful did it feel? *Not much* 1 2 3 4 5 *Very*

How confident am I about continuing? *Not yet* 1 2 3 4 5 *Very*

What I notice about myself after a week

Week 6: Reflect

Weekly Review

Take ten minutes to look back. The point is not to judge, but to learn what to adjust.

Days I did my habit (out of 7)

What worked best this week?

What got in the way?

Memory slips this week, and any pattern I notice

Decide

- ☐ **Keep** it as it is
- ☐ **Tweak** it (what will I change?)
- ☐ **Swap** it for something easier

My plan for next week

A note to my future self

- ☐ **Week complete. I celebrated.**

My Notes

Week 6: Reflect

Questions And Notes

Question	Answer
What if I want to do more than five minutes?	Go ahead, but keep five minutes as your non-negotiable floor.
Can I change my anchors?	Yes. If an anchor is unreliable, replace it. Better a steady anchor than a stubborn plan.
What happens after week six?	Keep going with whichever habits worked best, and use the Keep Going section.

Notes, doodles and questions for later

Part One: Everyday Memory Questionnaire

Your Final Self-Check

Repeat the questionnaire from week zero, again thinking about the **last month**. Answer honestly and do not look back at your first answers until you have finished.

0 = Never **1** = Sometimes **2** = Often **3** = Very Often

#	In the last month...	Score
1	I walk into a room and forget why I went there.	
2	I misplace keys, my phone, glasses or my wallet.	
3	I forget a person's name soon after hearing it.	
4	I struggle to find a familiar word in conversation.	
5	I forget a task or appointment I meant to do.	
6	I have to re-read or replay something because my attention drifted.	
7	After an interruption I lose track of what I was doing.	
8	I wonder whether I have done something (locked the door, sent the email).	
9	I leave the house without something I meant to take.	
10	I open an app or a browser tab and forget what I wanted.	
11	I repeat a story or question to the same person.	
12	I feel mentally foggy by mid-afternoon.	

My total (0 to 36): _____ Date: _____

My Notes

Part Two: Quick Recall Tasks

Your Final Self-Check

Task A: A New Ten-Word List

Step 1. Read these ten words once, slowly, about two seconds each.

compass · blanket · meadow · hammer · candle · lemon · river · mirror · saddle · pepper

Step 2. Spend five minutes on something else, such as Task B. **Step 3.** Write as many words as you can, without looking back.

Words I remembered

Words recalled: _____ out of 10 Date: _____

Task B: Yesterday In Order

Without checking your phone or calendar, list the main things you did yesterday, in order, with approximate times. Aim for at least six items.

Yesterday, from morning to night

Items recalled: _____ How easy was it? 1 = very hard, 5 = very easy: _____

My Notes

Then And Now

Compare And Reflect

Fill in the first two columns from your baseline self-check at the start of the workbook and your final self-check. A lower questionnaire score and a higher recall score both suggest improvement, but treat the numbers as a conversation starter rather than a verdict. Day-to-day variation is normal.

Measure	Baseline	Final	Change
Questionnaire total (0-36, lower is fewer slips)			
Ten-word recall (out of 10)			
Items recalled from yesterday			
How easy yesterday's recall felt (1-5)			

Reading Your Results

A difference of one or two points is within normal day-to-day variation, so do not over-read it. Look at the whole picture: slips, effort, mood and confidence.

If your numbers got worse, or you feel concerned, consider the doctor page again. Habits help, but they are not a substitute for a check-up.

What I notice when I compare them

The slip that has improved the most

The slip that still bothers me

Rate The Six Habits

Compare And Reflect

Think back over the six weeks and rate each habit. This tells you what to keep, what to adapt and what to leave behind.

Week 1: The Five-Minute Wind-Down (ease)	*Hard*	1	2	3	4	5	*Easy*
Week 1 (usefulness)	*Not much*	1	2	3	4	5	*Very*
Week 2: One Thing, Out Loud (ease)	*Hard*	1	2	3	4	5	*Easy*
Week 2 (usefulness)	*Not much*	1	2	3	4	5	*Very*
Week 3: The Five-Minute Movement Snack (ease)	*Hard*	1	2	3	4	5	*Easy*
Week 3 (usefulness)	*Not much*	1	2	3	4	5	*Very*
Week 4: Recall Before You Check (ease)	*Hard*	1	2	3	4	5	*Easy*
Week 4 (usefulness)	*Not much*	1	2	3	4	5	*Very*
Week 5: The Three-Second Tag (ease)	*Hard*	1	2	3	4	5	*Easy*
Week 5 (usefulness)	*Not much*	1	2	3	4	5	*Very*
Week 6: The Daily Five (ease)	*Hard*	1	2	3	4	5	*Easy*
Week 6 (usefulness)	*Not much*	1	2	3	4	5	*Very*

My top two habits to keep

A habit to adapt, and how

My Notes

Your Long-Term Plan

Keep Going

Six weeks is a start. The aim is a small set of habits that still run in a year. Decide what continues, and tie each habit to its anchor.

Habit	Keep, Swap Or Drop?	Anchor	Backup
The Five-Minute Wind-Down			
One Thing, Out Loud			
The Five-Minute Movement Snack			
Recall Before You Check			
The Three-Second Tag			
The Daily Five			

My Daily Five rotation in one sentence

When I will review this plan again (date)

What will help me keep going?

My Notes

Keep Going

Thirty-Day Calendar

Tick or colour each day you complete your five minutes. A day with just the two-minute version still counts.

Week	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
1							
2							
3							
4							
5							

How the month is going

Keep Going

Never Miss Twice

Missing a day is not failure, and it does not undo your progress. The single most helpful rule is to **return the very next day**, even in a smaller form. Write your relapse plan now, while you feel good.

Situations that usually derail me

The smallest version of my habit (two minutes or less)

If I miss a day, then I will…

If I miss two days, then I will…

A reminder of why this matters to me

Someone I can tell when I wobble

> **A Reminder**
> You are not starting from zero. Everything you tried in the last six weeks is still in you, and each return is practice at returning.

My Notes

Menu One

Sleep And Wind-Down Habits

Tick the ones you want to try. Each takes five minutes or less. Swap one in whenever a habit stops working or starts to feel stale.

- [ ] **Phone parking**
  Put your phone on charge outside the bedroom as the last act of the day.
- [ ] **Tomorrow list**
  Write tomorrow's top three tasks before bed.
- [ ] **Lights low**
  Dim the lights in your home half an hour before bed.
- [ ] **Breathe out slowly**
  Take six slow breaths, longer on the way out.
- [ ] **Caffeine curfew**
  Pick a cut-off time for caffeine and stick to it for a week.
- [ ] **Fixed wake time**
  Get up at the same time every day, even weekends, give or take half an hour.
- [ ] **Morning light**
  Step outside or sit by a window for five minutes in the morning.
- [ ] **Cool, dark room**
  Check the bedroom is cool, dark and quiet before you get in.
- [ ] **Gratitude line**
  Write one thing that went well today.
- [ ] **Screen-free page**
  Read paper or e-ink for five minutes instead of scrolling.

My Notes

Menu Two

Attention And Focus Habits

Tick the ones you want to try. Each takes five minutes or less. Swap one in whenever a habit stops working or starts to feel stale.

- [ ] **Single-task sprint**
  Set a timer and work on one task only.
- [ ] **Notifications off**
  Silence one noisy app for a week.
- [ ] **Say it aloud**
  Say where you put something as you put it down.
- [ ] **Tab trim**
  Close every tab you do not need before you stand up.
- [ ] **Eyes-up pause**
  Look out of a window for 30 seconds between tasks.
- [ ] **Mindful sip**
  Drink your first coffee or tea with no screen.
- [ ] **Two-minute tidy**
  Clear your desk or entry table before you leave it.
- [ ] **Parking note**
  Photograph or write where you left the car.
- [ ] **Meeting minute**
  Write one sentence of what you want from a meeting before it starts.
- [ ] **Phone-free meal**
  Eat one meal a day without a screen.

My Notes

Menu Three

Movement And Energy Habits

Tick the ones you want to try. Each takes five minutes or less. Swap one in whenever a habit stops working or starts to feel stale.

- [ ] **Stairs only**
  Take the stairs in one place every day.
- [ ] **Call walk**
  Walk during one phone call a day.
- [ ] **Doorway stretch**
  Stretch each time you pass through a doorway.
- [ ] **Kitchen squats**
  Do five sit-to-stands while the kettle boils.
- [ ] **Dance break**
  Move to one favourite song.
- [ ] **Lunch lap**
  Take a five-minute loop after you eat.
- [ ] **Park far**
  Park further away, or get off one stop early.
- [ ] **Posture reset**
  Roll your shoulders and stand tall each hour.
- [ ] **Evening saunter**
  Take a gentle walk after dinner.
- [ ] **Weekend wander**
  Choose one longer walk on a weekend day.

My Notes

Menu Four

Recall And Encoding Habits

Tick the ones you want to try. Each takes five minutes or less. Swap one in whenever a habit stops working or starts to feel stale.

- [ ] **Yesterday replay**
  Recall yesterday in order, then check.
- [ ] **Name recap**
  Say the names of people you met today before bed.
- [ ] **Shopping list first**
  Recall your shopping list from memory, then check it.
- [ ] **Teach one thing**
  Explain something you learned today to someone else.
- [ ] **Number chunk**
  Learn one phone number or code by chunking it.
- [ ] **Route recall**
  Picture the route you took today, in order.
- [ ] **Word of the day**
  Learn one new word and use it three times.
- [ ] **Story link**
  Link five items into a vivid little story.
- [ ] **Three things**
  Recall three things you read or heard today.
- [ ] **Review a card**
  Check one name or fact on a 1-3-7-day schedule.

My Notes

Page 1 Of 4

Memory Slip Log

Slips are information, not failure. Jot down what happened and what was going on. After a few weeks, patterns often appear: the same time of day, the same stressor, the same kind of task.

Date	What I Forgot Or Lost	What Was Going On?	What Might Help

My Notes

Page 2 Of 4

Memory Slip Log

Date	What I Forgot Or Lost	What Was Going On?	What Might Help

My Notes

Page 3 Of 4

Memory Slip Log

Date	What I Forgot Or Lost	What Was Going On?	What Might Help

My Notes

Page 4 Of 4

Memory Slip Log

Date	What I Forgot Or Lost	What Was Going On?	What Might Help

My Notes

Keep Your Streak Honest

Twelve-Week Habit Tracker

Colour in a box for each day you did your five minutes. Fill the last column with a one-word note.

Week	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun	Note
1								
2								
3								
4								
5								
6								
7								
8								
9								
10								
11								
12								

My Notes

Keep Your Streak Honest

Month-By-Month Check-In

Once a month, pause and take stock. What has changed? What needs adjusting? What are you proud of?

Month One

What is going well

What needs adjusting

Overall confidence *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Month Two

What is going well

What needs adjusting

Overall confidence *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

Month Three

What is going well

What needs adjusting

Overall confidence *Low* 1 2 3 4 5 *High*

A word to my future self

Page 1 Of 2

Spaced Recall Planner

Write each name or fact you want to keep. Review it after 1, 3, 7 and 14 days. Tick each review when done, and retire the item when you get it right three times in a row.

Name Or Fact	Date Learned	Day 1	Day 3	Day 7	Day 14

My Notes

Page 2 Of 2

Spaced Recall Planner

Name Or Fact	Date Learned	Day 1	Day 3	Day 7	Day 14

My Notes

Notes And Reflections

My Attention Notes

When is my attention strongest?

What drags it away?

What small change helped?

Notes And Reflections

My Body And Energy Notes

How does sleep change my day?

What does movement do for my focus?

What do I want to protect?

Notes And Reflections

My Environment Notes

Which homes for objects work?

What reminders help most?

What should I move or remove?

Notes And Reflections

A Letter To My Future Self

Dear me, in six months…

The Daily Five At A Glance

Quick Reference

Habit	The Five-Minute Recipe	Anchor Ideas
Wind-Down	Phone away, brain dump, six slow breaths.	Brushing teeth, plugging in phone
One Thing, Out Loud	Timer, one task, say where things go.	First coffee, sitting at desk
Movement Snack	Five minutes of brisk movement, recall as you go.	After lunch, before the school run
Recall Before You Check	Write what you remember, then check.	Kettle on, commuting, lunchtime
Three-Second Tag	Notice, say, link. Use it within a minute.	Meeting someone, parking, putting down keys

If-Then Templates

- After I **[anchor]**, I will **[five-minute habit]** in **[place]**.
- If I miss a day, then I will **do the two-minute version tomorrow**.
- If I feel too tired, then I will **do just one breath and tick the box**.
- If I am travelling, then I will **do the habit at the hotel or station**.
- If something interrupts me, then I will **resume the moment it ends**.

> **Remember**
> Small, specific and steady beats big and brief. Five minutes, every day you can, and back on track the day after you cannot.

My Notes

Quick Reference

Memory Tricks At A Glance

Trick	How It Works	Best For
Notice, Say, Link	Give a name or fact your full attention for three seconds, say it, link it to a picture.	Names, facts, new information
Place It, Say It, Picture It	Put things in the same home, say where as you place them, and picture it.	Keys, glasses, phone, wallet
Chunking	Break long strings into small groups.	Phone numbers, codes, dates
Story Link	Link each item to the next in a vivid story.	Lists, errands, speeches
Spaced Recall	Review after 1, 3, 7 and 14 days, recalling before you look.	Anything you want to keep
Brain Dump	Empty your head onto paper before bed.	Racing thoughts, tomorrow's plan
Never Miss Twice	Return the day after a miss, even in a tiny form.	Keeping habits alive

Habits Beat Tricks

Tricks help in the moment. Habits make them automatic. Keep using both.

My own tricks

Part One

Sources And Further Reading

These are the main studies and books behind the ideas in this workbook. They are listed so that you can read further. Research evolves, and the plain-language summaries here are simplified, so please consult the originals before relying on any detail.

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My Notes

Part Two

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A Note On Evidence

This workbook does not claim that any habit prevents or reverses memory disease. It uses well-established findings about attention, sleep, practice and habit formation to help with everyday forgetfulness.

Notes on what I want to read next

When You Want More Support

Help And Resources

If your memory worries you, a conversation is the best next step. Start with your family doctor, practice nurse or a pharmacist. In many countries a national health service website or a dementia or ageing charity offers plain-language information and helplines, and your doctor can point you to what is available where you live.

If you feel overwhelmed, very low, or unsafe, please reach out right away to a doctor, a trusted person or your local emergency or crisis service.

My Contacts

My doctor or clinic

My pharmacist

My support person

A local service or helpline I can use

Take Someone With You

If you do book an appointment about your memory, it often helps to bring a trusted friend or family member who can add what they have noticed.

Notes

Space For Whatever You Need

Notes And Doodles

You Did This

A Closing Note

Whatever your numbers say, you gave your memory a gentle, regular, practical push for six weeks. You paid attention to sleep, moved a little more, practised recall and learned to tag what matters. That is the work of caring for your mind, and it was worth the five minutes.

Memory is not a single skill that sits in one place and either works or does not. It is the sum of many small daily conditions: rest, focus, movement, practice and a life that is not asking you to hold everything in your head at once. You have now got tools for all of them.

Keep the habits that serve you and quietly drop the ones that do not. Come back to this book on busy weeks. Share it with a friend who keeps losing their keys. And if something worries you, ask a professional. That is not a failure of habits. It is part of looking after yourself well.

Thank you for spending these weeks with us. We hope you remember how good it feels to keep a promise to yourself.

With warm wishes,

Cimple Books

> **Keep Going**
> Pick your Daily Five rotation, check your anchors, and tick today's box.

My Promise To Myself

Thank You

About Cimple Books

Cimple Books creates practical workbooks and guides for everyday life: clear, usable and honest about what they can and cannot do.

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> **A Quick Reminder**
> This workbook is not medical advice. If you are worried about your memory, please talk to your doctor.

A sentence about what I will keep doing